



Onyx

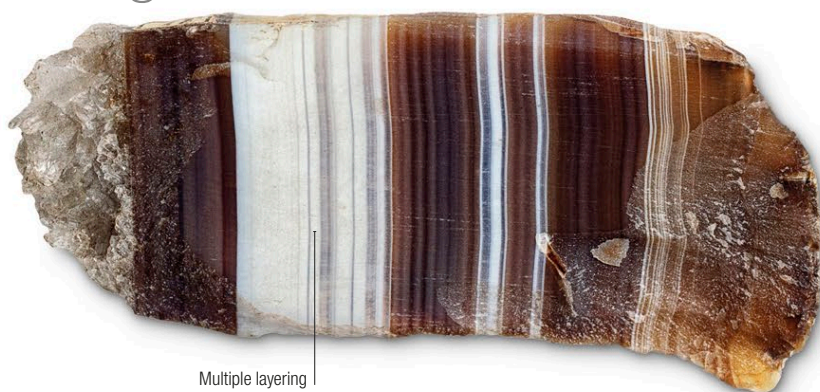
△ **Carnelian onyx cabochon** showing multiple layers of banding

Onyx is a striped, semi-precious variety of chalcedony quartz with alternating bands of black and white. Its varieties include carnelian onyx, which has white and red bands, and sardonyx, with white and brown bands; the name “onyx” is only properly applied to the black and white variety, but is also informally used for all varieties. Onyx is a popular material for cameos and intaglios because its layers can be cut to create a colour contrast. A quantity of the modern onyx on the market is produced artificially by dyeing pale, layered chalcedony.

Specification

Chemical name Silicon dioxide | **Formula** SiO_2 | **Colours** White colour-banded | **Structure** Trigonal | **Hardness** 7
SG 2.65 | **RI** 1.54–1.55 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White
Locations India, South America (onyx); Sri Lanka, India, Brazil, Uruguay (sard and sardonyx)

Rough



Multiple layering

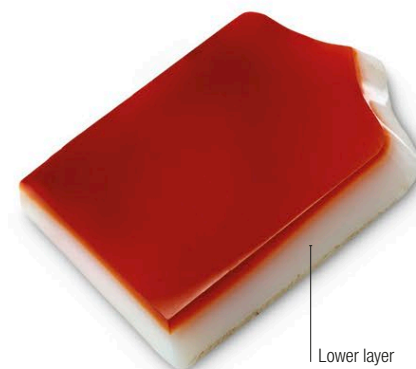
Onyx rough | This example is a fine-quality piece of onyx rough displaying multiple banding in several different colours, principally white, grey, brown, and purple. Colour layering such as this is highly desirable in onyx carving, and lends the characteristic layered appearance to cameos (see below).



Coloured layers

Polished slab | This excellent quality slab of onyx features dramatic, characteristic colour banding, and could be shaped to create a superb cabochon.

Cut



Lower layer

Shield shape | This shield-shaped onyx cabochon could be carved into a cameo: the top layer would form the subject, with the bottom layer as the background.

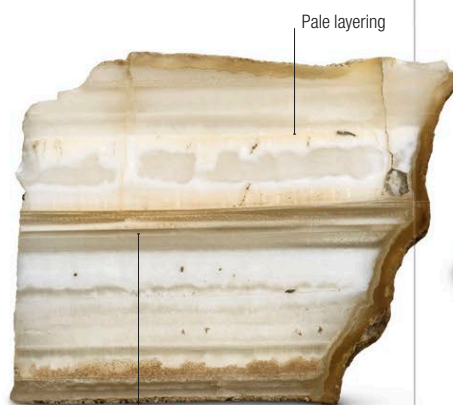
Roman cameos

Layers and contrast

The ancient Roman world produced some of the finest cameos ever made, and sardonyx in various colours and shades was the preferred medium. The intricacies of Roman carving and their use of the colour contrasts of the various layers remain unsurpassed. One unusually fine group of cameos, often referred to as the “State Cameos”, were of the Emperor Augustus, and show him with various divine attributes. One of the most stunning is the Blancas Cameo, now in the British Museum.

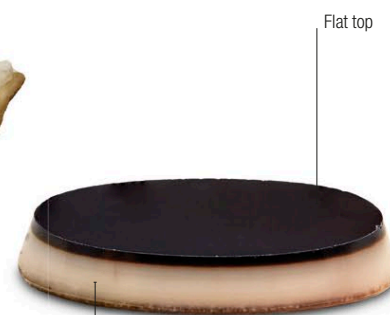


Roman cameo Onyx was a favourite medium for Roman cameo carvers – this one depicts an empress.



Dark central band

Slab with light banding | Onyx does not always need bold contrasts to be desirable. The light-coloured banding seen here makes it excellent carving material.



Flat top

White layer

Cabochon | The strong banding of onyx offers the lapidary a number of choices when cutting, as with this flat-topped cabochon showing clear contrast.